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Full IAM Roles & Career Framework

Vendor-agnostic reference for every major role in identity

11 role reference cards with Day-in-the-Life · Career progression paths · Skills matrix 5 career pathways from entry level to CISO

Mastering Identity Security for CIDPro™
Abbas Kudrati | 2026 Edition

11	**5**	**7**	**100+**
Role Cards	Career Paths	Specialisations	Skills Listed

Appendix B

IAM Roles, Career Framework & Day-in-the-Life Guide

A vendor-agnostic reference for every major role in identity — with what they do, a day in the life, and how to get there

Mastering Identity Security for CIDPro™ • Abbas Kudrati

Why Identity Is One of the Best Career Choices in Technology Today

Not every area of technology offers the combination of strong demand, meaningful work, good compensation, and long-term stability. Identity and access management does.

Consider these realities. Cybersecurity analysts consistently rank identity-related attacks — credential theft, account takeover, privilege abuse — as the leading cause of data breaches. Organisations know this. They are investing heavily in identity platforms, identity governance tools, and identity security programs. But the people who know how to build and run these systems are in short supply.

This shortage is global, but it is especially acute in Asia. As digital transformation accelerates across India, South-East Asia, and the broader Asia-Pacific region, the demand for identity professionals is growing faster than universities and training programs can produce them. This is your opportunity.

> *An identity career is a career with depth. It is not a field you exhaust quickly. Identity touches architecture, security, compliance, user experience, cloud infrastructure, privacy law, and business operations. The more you learn, the more interesting it becomes.*

Understanding the IAM Landscape

Identity and access management is sometimes described as a single discipline, but in practice it is a family of related specialisations. Understanding the landscape helps you choose the path that fits your skills and goals.

Specialisation	Focus Area
Workforce IAM	Managing the identities of employees, contractors, and partners through their full lifecycle — joiner, mover, leaver.
Customer IAM (CIAM)	Managing the identities of customers at large scale with a focus on user experience, privacy, and fraud prevention.
Identity Governance & Administration	Ensuring access is appropriate, auditable, and compliant — the oversight side of identity.

Specialisation	Focus Area
(IGA)	
Privileged Access Management (PAM)	Securing the highest-risk identities: system administrators, database administrators, and other elevated accounts.
Non-Human Identity (NHI) Management	Managing machine identities: service accounts, API keys, certificates, cloud workloads, and AI agents. The fastest-growing specialisation.
Identity Security / ITDR	Detecting and responding to identity-based threats: compromised credentials, abnormal access, lateral movement.
Identity Architecture	Designing enterprise-scale identity solutions, selecting protocols and patterns, managing technical debt across multi-year programmes.

Career Paths — Where Do You Start and Where Can You Go?

There is no single path into identity. People come from many different backgrounds — IT support, software development, network engineering, audit and compliance, and entirely different fields. What matters is that you build knowledge methodically and gain experience with real identity systems.

The Technical Path

IT Support / Helpdesk → IAM Analyst → IAM Administrator → IAM Engineer → Identity Architect

The most common path from a general IT background. Builds technical depth steadily, from operational tasks through to complex design work. CIDPro™ at the Administrator or Engineer stage significantly accelerates progression.

The Security Path

SOC Analyst → Identity Security Analyst → Identity Threat Engineer → Head of Identity Security

For people drawn to threat detection and incident response. The rise of Identity Threat Detection and Response (ITDR) has made this path increasingly strategic and well-compensated.

The Governance Path

IT Auditor / Risk Analyst → IGA Analyst → Identity Compliance Lead → Identity Risk Manager

Suits professionals with compliance, audit, or risk backgrounds applying that expertise to identity. Regulatory requirements are making IGA expertise more valuable every year.

The NHI / Machine Identity Path

DevOps Engineer / Cloud Engineer → NHI Engineer → NHI Platform Lead → Head of Machine Identity Security

One of the newest paths in identity, and currently the one with the greatest talent shortage. NHI expertise commands a significant premium as organisations recognise the scale of their machine identity exposure.

The Leadership Path

IAM Administrator / Engineer → IAM Team Lead → IAM Manager → Head of Identity → CISO

Identity is an increasingly common pipeline to the CISO role, because identity is so central to modern security strategy. CIDPro™ combined with CISSP or CISM is the credential combination most frequently seen in Identity leaders who move into CISO positions.

Role Reference Overview

The table below maps all eleven roles to career level, primary domain, and key CIDPro™ objectives. Detailed role cards follow on subsequent pages.

Role	Career Level	Primary Domain	Key CIDPro™ Objectives
Entry-Level IAM Analyst	Entry / Graduate	Operations	Obj 1, 2, 5.1
IAM Administrator	Junior / Mid	Operations	Obj 1, 2, 5.2, 5.3
IAM Engineer / Security Engineer	Mid / Senior	Engineering / Security	Obj 1, 2, 3, 4
IGA Specialist	Mid / Senior	Governance	Obj 2, 4, 5.2
PAM Leader	Senior / Director	Privileged Access	Obj 1, 3, 5.2, 4
IAM Product Manager	Mid / Senior	Product	Obj 1, 4, 5.1, 5.5
CIAM Product Manager	Mid / Senior	CIAM / Product	Obj 2, 4, 5.1, 5.4
IAM Architect — Leadership	Senior / Principal	Architecture	Obj 1–5 (all)
IAM Architect — Identity Standards	Principal / Distinguished	Architecture + Standards	Obj 4, 1–3
Senior IAM Developer	Senior / Lead	Engineering	Obj 1, 2, 3, 4
NHI Engineer	Mid / Senior	Security / NHI	Obj 1, 2, 5.2, 5.3

Role Reference Cards

Each card provides the complete reference profile for one IAM role. Cards are ordered from entry-level to senior and specialist roles. Each includes: what the role does, a day in the life, key skills, tools used, responsibilities, career progression, knowledge and qualifications, and CIDPro™ exam objective mappings.

Entry-Level IAM Systems Analyst

Career Level: Entry / Graduate

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: IAM Fundamentals • Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle • Obj 5.1: Customer Service • Obj 5.3: Event Monitoring (awareness)	• Ch 1–5 (Foundations) • Ch 6–8 (Identity Lifecycle) • Ch 13 (IGA) • Ch 16 (Compliance overview)

Role Overview

The first step into an IAM career. This role supports day-to-day identity operations: provisioning accounts, troubleshooting access issues, assisting with access reviews, and developing awareness of security and compliance requirements. An excellent entry point for recent graduates or IT support professionals building specialisation in identity.

What They Do

The IAM Systems Analyst handles the operational heartbeat of identity systems — creating and managing user accounts, processing access requests, running access reviews, handling password resets, and ensuring that joiners, movers, and leavers are processed correctly and on time. This role builds the foundational knowledge that all other identity roles build upon.

Key Skills

- Strong IT background and analytical problem-solving
- Attention to detail and a security-first mindset
- Customer focus and clear communication
- Collaboration within a cross-functional team
- Willingness to learn and pursue professional certifications

Tools Commonly Used

Microsoft Active Directory, Microsoft Entra ID, ServiceNow or Jira for ticketing, basic PowerShell scripting, IGA platforms (read-only / support access).

📅 A Day in the Life

A new employee is starting on Monday. The Analyst creates their account, assigns them to the right groups, provisions their access to the applications they need, and ensures their manager has approved the appropriate entitlements. On the same day, a contractor whose contract has ended needs to be offboarded — all accounts disabled, access removed, tokens revoked. Between those tasks, there are three access requests in the queue and two password reset tickets to resolve.

Key Responsibilities

- **Lifecycle Management:**
  - Provision, modify, and deactivate user accounts
  - Follow joiner-mover-leaver procedures aligned to HR data
- **Identity Governance:**
  - Assist with periodic access reviews and recertification campaigns
  - Maintain IGA tool configurations for access control
- **Access Management:**
  - Configure and support SSO and MFA solutions
  - Enforce least-privilege and RBAC policies
  - Troubleshoot user access escalations and resolve tickets
- **Security & Compliance:**
  - Monitor and respond to security alerts related to identity events
  - Assist with internal and external audits

↗️ Career Progression

This is the classic entry point from IT support or helpdesk into identity. After 2–3 years, most IAM Analysts progress to IAM Administrator (broader platform ownership) or IAM Engineer (deeper technical integration work). The CIDPro™ certification significantly accelerates this progression by providing the conceptual framework that distinguishes a specialist from a generalist.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Foundational understanding of IAM principles and cybersecurity concepts
- Awareness of IAM protocols: SAML, SCIM, OIDC, OAuth 2.0
- Understanding of regulatory requirements: GDPR, HIPAA, SOX
- Educational background or 2+ years of IT experience
- Willingness to pursue CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, or CIAM certification

IAM Administrator

Career Level: Junior / Mid-Level

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: IAM Concepts • Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle • Obj 5.2: Privilege Management • Obj 5.3: Identity Monitoring	• Ch 1–5 (Foundations) • Ch 6–8 (Lifecycle) • Ch 13 (IGA) • Ch 19 (PAM Ops) • Ch 20 (Event Monitoring)

Role Overview

The IAM Administrator operates and maintains secure identity environments. They manage the full user lifecycle, implement and monitor access controls, integrate IAM platforms with enterprise applications, and support incident response. A strong foundation for senior engineering or architecture paths.

What They Do

Where the Analyst handles individual tickets, the Administrator owns the systems. They configure and maintain IAM platforms, manage the joiner-mover-leaver lifecycle at scale, enforce access control policies, integrate identity platforms with business applications, and investigate access-related incidents. When something breaks — an SSO integration fails, a user is locked out of a critical application, an access review is overdue — the Administrator is the one who resolves it.

Key Skills

- Expertise in IAM platforms across cloud and on-premises environments
- Ability to assess system resilience, security, and impact of changes
- Stakeholder management and clear communication
- Collaboration and cross-functional teamwork
- Scripting and automation for lifecycle management

Tools Commonly Used

Microsoft Entra ID, Okta, Active Directory, ServiceNow, SailPoint or Saviynt (administration), PowerShell, SCIM-enabled applications.

📅 A Day in the Life

Monday morning: the access review campaign is two days overdue — the Administrator sends reminders to managers, processes completed reviews, and escalates revocations for accounts that failed review. Mid-morning: an SSO integration with a new SaaS tool breaks after an update — the Administrator debugs the SAML metadata, identifies a certificate mismatch, and fixes it. Afternoon: a quarterly entitlement cleanup job runs — the Administrator reviews the results, disables dormant accounts, and documents the actions taken for the compliance record.

Key Responsibilities

- **Operating a Secure Environment:**
  - Monitor system availability, security, and stability
  - Maintain IGA frameworks, policies, and processes
  - Perform regular access reviews and audits
- **User Lifecycle Management:**
  - Enforce access control policies across all IAM applications
  - Manage JML lifecycle with automation where possible

  - Respond to user access escalations, bugs, and outages
- **Incident Response:**
  - Investigate identity-related security incidents
  - Identify root causes and drive remediation
- **Supporting Change:**
  - Integrate IAM platforms with third-party applications
  - Partner with architecture teams to implement designs

↗️ Career Progression

After 3–5 years as an Administrator, professionals typically choose between two paths: the technical path toward IAM Engineer or Identity Security Analyst (deeper protocol and integration work), or the governance path toward IGA Analyst or Compliance Lead. The Administrator role builds the broadest operational foundation in identity.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Hands-on experience with IAM platforms in hybrid environments
- Familiarity with SAML, SCIM, OIDC, OAuth 2.0
- Knowledge of PAM, Directories, SSO, MFA, threat detection
- Experience with IaaS and SaaS platforms
- Familiarity with NIST 800-63, GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, SOX
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

IAM Engineer / Identity Security Engineer

Career Level: Mid / Senior

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: IAM Concepts • Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle • Obj 3: Authentication & Security • Obj 4: IAM Standards	• Ch 3 (Authentication) • Ch 4 (Authorisation) • Ch 5 (Federation) • Ch 9 (Zero Trust) • Ch 10–11 (MFA & RBA) • Ch 17 (Standards)

Role Overview

The IAM Engineer builds and integrates identity systems. Where the Administrator runs existing systems, the Engineer designs and implements new ones — setting up SSO integrations, configuring MFA, deploying SCIM provisioning, building federation connections, and hardening authentication across hybrid environments.

What They Do

The IAM Engineer is the technical implementer of identity capabilities. They onboard new applications to SSO, build SCIM provisioning pipelines, configure Conditional Access policies, implement passwordless authentication, and harden identity posture by eliminating legacy authentication paths. The Security Engineer variant focuses specifically on identity threat detection, risk-based authentication tuning, and incident investigation.

Key Skills

- Protocol-level knowledge of SAML, OAuth 2.0/OIDC, SCIM, FIDO2
- Scripting and automation (PowerShell, Python, REST APIs)
- Policy design and access control engineering
- Security mindset and threat modelling
- Analytical troubleshooting of distributed authentication flows

Tools Commonly Used

Okta, Microsoft Entra ID, Ping Identity, SailPoint, CyberArk, HashiCorp Vault, Azure DevOps, Postman (API testing), Python/PowerShell.

📅 A Day in the Life

A business unit has onboarded a new SaaS project management tool. The IAM Engineer integrates it with the organisation's identity provider using OIDC, configures attribute mappings so that user roles are assigned correctly based on group membership, sets up automated provisioning using SCIM, and tests the full SSO and deprovisioning flow before go-live. In the afternoon, an alert surfaces: a service account is authenticating to a system outside its defined scope. The Engineer investigates, identifies a misconfigured application, and applies a virtual fencing policy to restrict the account's authentication paths.

Key Responsibilities

- **Design and Implement Identity Solutions:**
  - Design Conditional Access, authentication policies, and authorisation controls
  - Implement SSO integrations, SCIM provisioning, and lifecycle automation
  - Maintain patterns and runbooks for IAM deployments

- **Secure Identity Posture:**
  - Harden authentication by eliminating legacy auth paths
  - Implement JIT access patterns and privileged role separation
  - Conduct sign-in anomaly investigation and risk-based authentication tuning
- **Application Integration:**
  - Onboard applications to SSO, SCIM, and governance workflows
  - Maintain application integration documentation
- **Incident Response:**
  - Investigate identity-related security incidents
  - Support security operations with identity context for alert triage

↗️ Career Progression

IAM Engineer is typically the role professionals move into after 2–3 years as an Administrator, or directly from a software development or systems integration background. From here, paths lead to Identity Architect (broader design responsibility), Identity Security Analyst (deeper threat detection focus), or IAM Team Lead (people management).

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Deep knowledge of IAM protocols: SAML, SCIM, OIDC, OAuth 2.0, FIDO2
- Experience with Conditional Access, Identity Protection, risk-based authentication
- Scripting and automation skills
- Experience across Cloud, On-Premises, IaaS, and SaaS
- Familiarity with NIST 800-63, GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, SOX
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

Identity Governance & Administration (IGA) Specialist

Career Level: Mid / Senior

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle • Obj 1: IAM Concepts (RBAC) • Obj 4: Compliance Frameworks • Obj 5.2: Privilege Management	• Ch 6 (JML Lifecycle) • Ch 7 (Directories) • Ch 13 (IGA) • Ch 15–16 (Compliance) • Ch 19 (PAM)

Role Overview

The IGA Specialist ensures that access within an organisation is appropriate, well-governed, and auditable. This role owns joiner-mover-leaver processes, access certification campaigns, entitlement management, and role lifecycle — making access governance a measurable, auditable control rather than a periodic checkbox exercise.

What They Do

The IGA Specialist is the bridge between the technical identity platform and the compliance and audit requirements of the business. They run access certification campaigns where managers confirm or revoke their team members' access, manage role definitions and separation of duties policies, enforce least-privilege principles, and produce reports that demonstrate compliance to auditors and regulators.

Key Skills

- Process design and structured analytical thinking
- RBAC and role engineering methodology
- Stakeholder management — working with compliance, audit, and business teams
- IGA platform configuration and workflow automation
- Clear documentation and regulatory reporting

Tools Commonly Used

SailPoint IdentityNow or IdentityIQ, Saviynt, One Identity, IBM Security Verify Governance, ServiceNow (for approval workflows).

📅 A Day in the Life

It is quarter-end, which means it is time for the quarterly access certification campaign. The IGA Specialist launches the campaign in SailPoint, notifies all managers that they need to review and certify or revoke their team members' access, monitors the completion dashboard, follows up with non-respondents, and processes completed revocations. By Friday, the Specialist produces the completion report for the compliance team showing that all access has been reviewed and inappropriate access has been removed — ready for the external auditor next week.

Key Responsibilities

- **Access Governance:**
  - Design and maintain role models, access profiles, and entitlement catalogues
  - Own access certification campaigns — schedule, execute, and track remediation
  - Enforce least-privilege principles across the identity lifecycle
- **Identity Lifecycle:**
  - Define and maintain JML process rules in IGA platforms
  - Ensure timely provisioning and deprovisioning triggered by HR events

   - Manage orphaned account detection and remediation
- **Compliance Support:**
   - Produce access reports and evidence packages for audit (SOX, GDPR, HIPAA)
   - Maintain governance documentation and exception registers
- **Continuous Improvement:**
   - Identify automation opportunities in access request and review workflows

↗️ Career Progression

IGA Analysts often come from audit, compliance, IT risk, or IT operations backgrounds. This role bridges the technical and business sides of identity — it requires both platform knowledge and the ability to communicate with non-technical stakeholders. Progression typically leads to Identity Compliance Lead, Identity Risk Manager, or IGA Architect.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Understanding of IGA platforms and access governance principles
- Experience with RBAC, role lifecycle management, and entitlement management
- Knowledge of access certification, separation of duties, and lifecycle automation
- Familiarity with SOX, GDPR, HIPAA regulatory requirements
- Experience with SCIM, SAML, OIDC
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

Privileged Access Management (PAM) Leader

Career Level: Senior / Director

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: Identity Fundamentals • Obj 3: Security Controls • Obj 5.2: Privilege Management • Obj 4: Compliance Standards	• Ch 9 (Zero Trust) • Ch 10 (MFA) • Ch 15–16 (Compliance) • Ch 19 (PAM Operations — full chapter) • Ch 22 (Identity at Scale)

Role Overview

The PAM Leader owns the enterprise-wide strategy, architecture, and operations of privileged access management. This role ensures that privileged accounts — human and non-human — are governed, monitored, and protected. PAM consistently ranks as the highest-priority identity security investment for enterprise organisations.

What They Do

The PAM Leader is responsible for securing the most sensitive accounts in the enterprise — the administrator accounts, service accounts, and system credentials that attackers target above all others. They design and operate the PAM programme: defining which accounts need vaulting, configuring session recording, managing just-in-time access workflows, and ensuring that privileged access is only available when genuinely needed.

Key Skills

- Deep expertise in PAM strategy and platforms
- Stakeholder management and influence of senior leadership
- Security policy writing and enforcement
- Ability to track emerging threats and PAM best practices
- Team leadership and budget management

Tools Commonly Used

CyberArk, BeyondTrust, Delinea, Silverfort, HashiCorp Vault, Microsoft PIM, Privileged Identity Management reporting tools.

📅 A Day in the Life

A senior database administrator needs emergency access to a production database to investigate a performance issue. They submit a just-in-time access request through the PAM portal. The PAM Leader reviews the policy that governs this access tier, confirms the request meets the criteria, approves a time-limited session, and the session is recorded for audit purposes. Simultaneously, the PAM Leader is reviewing the weekly privileged account hygiene report — 23 service accounts have not been used in 90 days and are flagged for review. A meeting with the security architecture team is scheduled to discuss the next phase of vaultless PAM deployment.

Key Responsibilities

- **Develop PAM Roadmap:**
  - Build data-driven insights on PAM performance
  - Develop PAM roadmap using insights, regulation, and best practice
- **Architect PAM Solutions:**
  - Collaborate with technical teams to design PAM architecture

  - Create and maintain architectural documents, use cases, test cases
- **Drive Automation:**
  - Develop strategies for automating provisioning, deprovisioning, and review of privileged accounts
  - Continuously streamline PAM processes
- **Risk Management:**
  - Identify, assess, and mitigate PAM-related risks
  - Continuously review privileged account hygiene
  - Investigate PAM-related security incidents
- **Financial & People Leadership:**
  - Conduct cost/benefit analysis and justify PAM investments
  - Manage and develop a PAM team

↗️ Career Progression

PAM Leader is a senior role typically reached after 7–10 years across identity and security disciplines, often via a PAM Administrator or Identity Security Analyst path. Many PAM Leaders progress to Head of Identity, CISO-adjacent roles, or advisory positions. The PAM domain is increasingly a CISO pipeline given its central role in breach prevention.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Proven experience with PAM platforms across Cloud, On-Premises, IaaS, and SaaS
- Strong foundation in IAM and cybersecurity
- Proficiency with MFA, SSO, and threat detection
- Familiarity with NIST 800-63, GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, SOX
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CyberArk Defender/Sentry, or equivalent

IAM Product Manager

Career Level: Mid / Senior

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: IAM Fundamentals • Obj 4: Standards & Regulations • Obj 5.1: Customer Service • Obj 5.5: Operational Implications	• Ch 1–5 (Foundations) • Ch 14 (CIAM) • Ch 15–17 (Standards) • Ch 18 (Customer Service) • Ch 22 (Identity at Scale)

Role Overview

The IAM Product Manager drives the strategic roadmap for identity and access management capabilities, balancing security, compliance, user experience, and business value. This role bridges business stakeholders, engineering, legal, and operations teams to deliver measurable IAM outcomes.

What They Do

The IAM Product Manager is not a technical implementer — they are a strategic translator. They turn business requirements into identity platform features, prioritise the roadmap based on data and stakeholder input, define success metrics, and work with engineering to deliver IAM capabilities that serve the organisation's goals. They are responsible for the IAM programme's direction, not its day-to-day operations.

Key Skills

- Stakeholder management and influence of senior leadership
- Roadmap development and data-driven prioritisation
- Change management in complex organisations
- Budget management and financial justification of IAM investments
- Strong written and verbal communication to non-technical audiences

Tools Commonly Used

Jira, Confluence, Microsoft 365, identity platform dashboards, reporting tools, market research tools.

📅 A Day in the Life

The morning begins with a sprint review — the engineering team has delivered the automated SCIM provisioning for three new SaaS applications, ahead of the quarter target. The afternoon is a business case session: the CISO wants to accelerate the MFA rollout following a phishing campaign. The Product Manager needs to estimate the effort, identify the user populations to phase first, coordinate with HR on communication, and present a revised timeline to the executive team by end of week. In between, there is a vendor briefing on a new IGA platform — the PM is evaluating whether it solves the access review bottleneck that compliance flagged last quarter.

Key Responsibilities

- **Develop IAM Roadmap:**
  - Build data-driven insights and optimise performance
  - Lead cross-functional teams to define target-state IAM requirements
  - Drive continuous improvement and automation
- **Implement IAM Projects:**
  - Define use cases, user stories, and requirements
  - Collaborate with engineering to scope architecture

    - Partner with legal, regulatory, and operational teams to deliver
- **IAM Performance Management:**
    - Establish metrics and reporting on costs, benefits, and performance
    - Conduct regular application security and performance reviews
- **Risk Management:**
    - Identify, assess, and mitigate IAM-related risks
    - Support root cause identification for IAM-related incidents

↗️ Career Progression

IAM Product Managers typically come from an IAM technical background (Engineer or Administrator) who has developed strong communication and business skills, or from a product management background who has specialised in identity. Progression leads to Head of IAM Product, VP of Identity Engineering, or CIAM Director.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Strong foundation in IAM technology and cybersecurity
- Awareness of SAML, SCIM, OIDC, OAuth 2.0
- Background in ITIL or ITSM
- Experience with IAM architecture across Cloud, On-Premises, IaaS, SaaS
- Familiarity with NIST 800-63, GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, SOX
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

Customer IAM (CIAM) Product Manager

Career Level: Mid / Senior

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle (consumer) • Obj 4: Regulations (GDPR, CCPA) • Obj 5.1: Customer Service • Obj 5.4: Privacy	• Ch 6–8 (Lifecycle) • Ch 14 (CIAM) • Ch 15–16 (Compliance) • Ch 18 (Customer Service) • Ch 21 (Privacy)

Role Overview

The CIAM Product Manager owns the customer-facing identity and access management experience — from registration and authentication to account recovery and consent management. This role focuses on increasing customer conversion, enhancing user experience, preventing fraud, and ensuring regulatory compliance across the consumer identity stack.

What They Do

The CIAM Product Manager is responsible for how millions of customers experience their digital identity with the organisation — how easy it is to register, how friction-free authentication is, how well account recovery works, and how privacy is respected. They balance the competing demands of security (prevent fraud), experience (don't lose customers to friction), and compliance (GDPR, PDPA, CCPA).

Key Skills

- Deep understanding of consumer identity and user experience
- Ability to track emerging consumer needs, competitor products, and security issues
- Data-driven product roadmap development
- Cross-functional collaboration with marketing, legal, and engineering
- Strong communication of security requirements to non-technical stakeholders

Tools Commonly Used

Auth0, Okta Customer Identity Cloud, Microsoft Entra External ID (Azure AD B2C), ForgeRock, Ping Identity, analytics and funnel tools.

📅 A Day in the Life

A bank is launching a new mobile banking application for retail customers. The CIAM Product Manager designs the registration flow — how customers create their account, how they prove their identity during KYC, what authentication methods are available (passkey, SMS OTP, biometric), how consent is captured for data processing under GDPR, and how account recovery works when a customer loses their phone. In the afternoon, the conversion funnel report flags a 12% drop-off at the MFA enrolment step — the CIAM PM convenes a UX review to diagnose whether the friction is necessary or can be reduced without compromising security.

Key Responsibilities

- **Develop CIAM Strategy and Roadmap:**
  - Work with customer insights teams to identify CX improvement areas
  - Build data-driven insights to optimise CIAM performance
  - Prioritise the CIAM product roadmap using insights and regulation
- **Implement CIAM Projects:**
  - Define use cases, user stories, and requirements

    - Collaborate with engineering, legal, marketing, and operational teams
- **Review CIAM Performance:**
    - Establish P&L metrics and reporting on CIAM stack
    - Continuously review CIAM performance for policy and regulatory compliance
    - Identify, assess, and mitigate CIAM-related risks

↗️ Career Progression

CIAM Product Managers typically come from a CIAM technical background, digital product management, or marketing technology. Progression leads to Director of Customer Identity, Head of CIAM, or VP of Digital Experience. CIAM expertise is particularly valuable in financial services, retail, and healthcare.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Proven experience with CIAM platforms and solutions
- Familiarity with SAML, SCIM, OIDC, OAuth 2.0
- Proficiency with consumer security: MFA, passkeys, federation, SSO, identity verification
- Familiarity with NIST 800-63, GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, SOX
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

IAM Architect — Leadership

Career Level: Senior Architect / Principal

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: IAM Foundations • Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle • Obj 3: Security Architecture • Obj 4: Standards & Compliance • Obj 5.5: Operational Implications	• Ch 1–8 (Foundations & Lifecycle) • Ch 9–14 (Security) • Ch 15–17 (Standards) • Ch 21 (Privacy) • Ch 22 (Scale & Architecture)

Role Overview

The IAM Architect defines and stewards the target-state identity architecture across the enterprise. They evaluate trade-offs, manage technical debt, design multi-channel patterns for authentication and lifecycle, and ensure security and privacy by design are embedded in every architectural decision.

What They Do

The Identity Architect does not configure systems — they design them. They define the strategic direction for how an organisation's identity infrastructure should evolve, select the right patterns and protocols, make trade-off decisions between security and usability, and ensure that today's choices do not create tomorrow's technical debt. They work on multi-year programmes, influencing every identity decision across the enterprise.

Key Skills

- Deep and broad knowledge of all identity domains
- Enterprise architecture principles and cloud platforms
- Ability to influence senior leadership and cross-functional teams
- Design patterns and system trade-off analysis
- Strong communication to boards and executives

Tools Commonly Used

LucidChart, Visio, full range of identity platforms, architecture frameworks (TOGAF, SABSA), cloud architecture tools.

📅 A Day in the Life

An organisation is moving its entire application portfolio to the cloud over three years. The Identity Architect is responsible for designing the target-state identity architecture — deciding which identity provider to use, how to handle legacy on-premises applications that cannot be modernised, how to federate with partner organisations using standards-based trust, how to implement Zero Trust access policies, and how to meet the regulatory requirements of the six countries in which the organisation operates. The morning is a whiteboard session with the engineering leads. The afternoon is a presentation to the board's Risk Committee explaining the architecture decisions and their security implications in plain language.

Key Responsibilities

- **Design Target-State Architecture:**
  - Collaborate with engineering and business units to design IAM architecture
  - Evaluate trade-offs and manage technical debt
  - Design multi-channel patterns for provisioning, recovery, authentication, authorisation
- **Target State Delivery:**

  - Scope engineering design for target-state IAM
  - Ensure Security-by-Design and Privacy-by-Design in all deliverables
  - Create and maintain architectural documentation
- **Risk Management:**
  - Identify, assess, and mitigate architectural risks
  - Investigate incidents to identify root causes and drive architectural remediation

↗️ Career Progression

Identity Architect is reached after 7–10 years across multiple identity domains, typically via IAM Engineer or Identity Security paths. Senior architects progress to Principal Architect, Head of Identity Architecture, Distinguished Engineer, or CTO-adjacent roles. Some move into the Identity Standards track, contributing to IETF or OpenID Foundation working groups.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Strong foundation in IAM, cybersecurity, privacy, and user data management
- Familiarity with SAML, SPML, XACML, SCIM, OIDC, OAuth 2.0
- Experience across Cloud, On-Premises, IaaS, and SaaS
- Deep understanding of common deployment models
- Familiarity with NIST 800-63, GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, SOX
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

IAM Architect — Identity Standards

Career Level: Principal / Distinguished Architect

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 4: IAM Standards & Standards Bodies • Obj 1–3: All Foundational Objectives • Obj 5.5: Operational Implications	• Ch 2–3 (Auth & AuthZ protocols) • Ch 5 (Federation) • Ch 15 (Compliance) • Ch 17 (Core IAM Standards — full chapter)

Role Overview

This highly specialised role sits at the intersection of enterprise IAM architecture and the global standards community. In addition to all architect responsibilities, this role represents the organisation in Standards Development Organisations such as IETF, OpenID Foundation, OASIS, FIDO Alliance, and W3C — contributing to the protocols that shape the entire identity industry.

What They Do

The Identity Standards Architect does everything the IAM Architect does, and then participates in the global standards bodies that define how identity works at an internet scale. They review proposed protocol extensions, contribute implementation experience from production deployments, and ensure their organisation's architectural choices align with and contribute to the direction of the standards community.

Key Skills

- All Architecture Leadership skills
- Ability to influence at an industry and standards-community level
- Cross-industry collaboration in public standards bodies
- Expert-level design patterns knowledge across all IAM protocol areas

Tools Commonly Used

All architecture tools plus IETF datatracker, OpenID Foundation repositories, standards editing tools, GitHub for RFC contribution.

📅 A Day in the Life

The morning begins with a review of a new draft RFC in the IETF WIMSE (Workload Identity in Multi-System Environments) working group — the Standards Architect submits comments based on their organisation's implementation experience with workload identity across Kubernetes clusters. The afternoon is a design session with internal architects, applying the emerging SPIFFE standard to a new cloud workload deployment. Between these, there is a thought leadership article to finish for an industry publication, explaining why the organisation's approach to FIDO2 attestation serves as a model for others.

Key Responsibilities

- **All Architecture Leadership responsibilities (see above):**
- **Standards Development:**
  - Engage in SDO communities: IETF, OpenID Foundation, OASIS, FIDO Alliance, W3C
  - Contribute to prioritised standards efforts to solve company challenges in a standardised manner
  - Provide internal guidance on applying or extending industry standards in the organisation's architecture
  - Establish the organisation as a thought leader on strategically relevant standards topics

↗️ Career Progression

This is the most senior individual contributor path in the identity profession. Progression beyond this role typically means taking a senior technical advisory or executive role, or becoming a recognised industry fellow. Standards architects often become sought-after conference keynote speakers, IDPro Body of Knowledge authors, and external advisors to regulators and governments.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Expert-level knowledge of IAM protocols: SAML, SCIM, FIDO2/WebAuthn, OIDC, OAuth 2.0, DPoP, CAEP, SPIFFE
- Active participation or contribution record in recognised SDOs
- Strong foundation in IAM, cybersecurity, privacy
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

Senior IAM Developer / Engineer

Career Level: Senior / Lead

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: IAM Concepts & Protocols • Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle • Obj 3: Authentication & Security • Obj 4: Standards	• Ch 1–5 (Foundations) • Ch 6–8 (Lifecycle) • Ch 9–11 (Security) • Ch 17 (Standards) • Ch 12 (NHI)

Role Overview

The Senior IAM Developer designs and builds secure, scalable identity solutions. They implement IAM capabilities to specification, drive automation, maintain system security, and contribute to the strategic direction of IAM systems alongside product and architecture teams.

What They Do

The Senior IAM Developer writes the code that makes identity systems work. They build the integrations, the automation pipelines, the custom extensions, and the APIs that connect identity platforms to the rest of the enterprise. Unlike an Administrator who configures existing features, the Developer extends and customises the platform — building custom authentication flows, writing provisioning connectors, developing identity APIs, and implementing CI/CD pipelines for identity infrastructure.

Key Skills

- Authoritative knowledge of secure software development and CI/CD processes
- Identity proofing, identity verification, fraud prevention, and detection
- Deep familiarity with IAM protocols and REST APIs
- Platform-specific development skills (Okta Workflows, SailPoint BeanShell, Entra ID PowerShell)

Tools Commonly Used

Git, GitHub/GitLab, CI/CD pipelines, REST APIs, Postman, PowerShell, Python, Java, SailPoint, Okta, Microsoft Entra ID developer tools.

📅 A Day in the Life

A new joiners workflow needs to be automated — the Developer writes a SCIM-based provisioning connector for a legacy HR system that does not support modern APIs, tests it against a staging environment, and deploys it through the CI/CD pipeline. In the afternoon, an identity governance team member reports that access reviews are generating too many false positives — the Developer analyses the underlying role data, identifies a data quality issue in the HR feed, and writes a transformation rule to normalise the data before it reaches the IGA platform.

Key Responsibilities

- **Design and Build Identity Solutions:**
  - Architect and implement identity solutions to specification
  - Ensure performance, maintainability, and security of implementation
  - Maintain systems by addressing emerging functional and security issues
- **Secure Development:**
  - Ensure scalability of secure development and production environments
  - Design and implement automation for hardened systems and releases
- **CI/CD Pipeline:**

  - Utilise and assist in managing an optimised CI/CD pipeline for identity infrastructure
- **Incident Response:**
  - Support security incident investigations related to IAM
  - Identify root causes and drive remediation

↗️ Career Progression

Senior IAM Developers typically come from a software engineering background who have specialised in identity, or from IAM Administrator/Engineer roles who have developed deep coding skills. Progression leads to Principal Engineer, Identity Platform Architect, or Engineering Lead. Some move into product management as they accumulate domain knowledge.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Authoritative knowledge of IAM and cybersecurity
- Authoritative knowledge of secure software development, CI/CD, and test automation
- Extensive knowledge of identity proofing, verification, fraud prevention
- Deep familiarity with SAML, SCIM, OIDC, OAuth 2.0
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, CISSP, CISM, CIAM

Non-Human Identity (NHI) Engineer / Service Account Specialist

Career Level: Mid / Senior

CIDPro™ Exam Objectives	Primary Book Chapters
• Obj 1: Identity Concepts (NHI) • Obj 2: Identity Lifecycle (NHI) • Obj 3: Security Controls • Obj 5.2: Privilege Management • Obj 5.3: Monitoring	• Ch 4 (Authorisation) • Ch 12 (Non-Human Identities — full chapter) • Ch 19 (PAM — Secrets) • Ch 20 (Monitoring — AI Agents) • Ch 22 (Operating at Scale)

Role Overview

An emerging and rapidly growing specialisation, the NHI Engineer governs all identities that are not people: service accounts, API keys, OAuth tokens, managed identities, CI/CD pipeline credentials, and AI agent identities. This is the largest current governance gap in identity security — and the fastest-growing professional opportunity.

What They Do

The NHI Engineer is responsible for the identities that most organisations do not manage well — and that attackers target relentlessly. Over 50 million leaked API keys, service accounts, and tokens were found on the dark web in 2024. The NHI Engineer discovers, classifies, governs, and secures all of these non-human credentials, ensuring that every machine identity has an owner, a defined purpose, least-privilege access, and a rotation schedule.

Key Skills

- Deep knowledge of NHI authentication patterns: service accounts, API keys, OAuth tokens, managed identities
- Secrets management platform expertise
- Scripting and automation for NHI lifecycle management
- Security mindset applied to machine credential governance
- Cross-team collaboration with DevOps, cloud, and application teams

Tools Commonly Used

HashiCorp Vault, CyberArk Secrets Manager, AWS Secrets Manager, Azure Key Vault, Kubernetes service accounts, Entro, Astrix, GitGuardian.

📅 A Day in the Life

A development team has just deployed a new microservices application on Kubernetes. The NHI Engineer reviews the deployment: discovers 14 service accounts were created without owner attribution, finds 3 API keys hardcoded in environment variables (an immediate security risk), and identifies 2 OAuth tokens with Global Administrator permissions — far beyond what the application needs. The Engineer remediates: moves secrets to HashiCorp Vault, applies runtime injection for dynamic credentials, reduces OAuth token scopes to the minimum required, and registers all 14 service accounts in the NHI inventory with owners and quarterly review dates. In the afternoon, the weekly NHI hygiene report flags 47 service accounts that have not authenticated in 90 days — the Engineer initiates the review and decommissioning workflow.

Key Responsibilities

- **NHI Discovery and Inventory:**
  - Continuously discover and classify all non-human identities across the enterprise
  - Maintain an authoritative NHI inventory with owner, purpose, and expiry attributes

- **Secrets Management:**
  - Govern privileged credentials, API keys, certificates, and tokens
  - Implement runtime injection patterns to eliminate hardcoded credentials
  - Enforce credential rotation policies and monitor for credential exposure
- **Lifecycle Governance:**
  - Apply JML-equivalent processes to NHI: create with purpose, scope to least privilege, review quarterly, retire when no longer needed
  - Define and enforce virtual fencing policies for service accounts
- **AI Agent Identity Governance:**
  - Inventory AI agents as NHI identities
  - Define permitted scope, authenticate with managed identities, enforce JIT access
  - Monitor agent authentication behaviour for anomalies

↗️ Career Progression

NHI Engineering is one of the newest and fastest-growing specialisations in identity. Most NHI Engineers come from DevOps, cloud security, or traditional PAM backgrounds. The field is so new that career paths are still being defined — but NHI leads are increasingly becoming dedicated practice leads, NHI Platform Architects, or transition into broader Identity Security leadership roles.

Expected Knowledge and Qualifications

- Knowledge of NHI types: service accounts, managed identities, API keys, OAuth tokens, CI/CD credentials
- Secrets management platforms (cloud-native and third-party)
- Understanding of agentic AI identity and governance requirements
- Experience with SCIM, OAuth 2.0, OIDC, and JWT token management
- Familiarity with Zero Trust principles applied to workload identity
- Professional certifications: CIDPro™, NHI Foundation (NHIMG), CISSP, CISM

Skills Matrix — Across All Roles

The table below maps key competency areas to each role (✓ = required, ○ = beneficial). Use this as a gap analysis tool for career development.

Competency	Entry Analyst	Admin	IAM Eng	IGA Spec	PAM Lead	IAM PM	CIAM PM	Architect	Stds Arch	Sr Dev	NHI Eng
IAM Protocol knowledge	○	✓	✓	○	○	○	○	✓	✓	✓	✓
User lifecycle / JML	✓	✓	✓	✓	○	○	○	○	○	✓	✓
MFA & authentication	○	✓	✓	○	○	○	○	✓	✓	✓	○
Identity Governance	○	✓	✓	✓	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
PAM / Secrets	○	○	○	○	✓	○	○	✓	○	○	✓
Zero Trust architecture	○	○	✓	○	✓	○	○	✓	✓	✓	✓
CIAM / consumer identity	○	○	○	○	○	○	✓	○	○	○	○
Privacy & data protection	○	○	○	✓	○	○	✓	✓	✓	○	○
Compliance (SOX/GDPR)	○	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	○	○
Secure software / CI/CD	○	○	✓	○	○	○	○	○	○	✓	○
NHI / AI agent governance	○	○	○	○	✓	○	○	○	○	○	✓
Stakeholder / exec comms	○	○	○	○	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	○	○
Product / roadmap mgmt	○	○	○	○	○	✓	✓	○	○	○	○
Standards body engagement	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	✓	○	○
Security incident response	○	✓	✓	○	✓	○	○	✓	○	✓	✓
Budget & financial leadership	○	○	○	○	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	○	○

A Final Word

Identity is not the most glamorous corner of cybersecurity. It lacks the drama of red team operations and the elegance of cryptographic proofs. But it is, increasingly, the field that everything else in security depends on. Every Zero Trust architecture needs an identity layer. Every compliance programme needs access governance. Every AI agent deployment needs an identity framework.

The organisations that take identity seriously are the ones that survive sophisticated attacks. The professionals who build expertise in identity — who earn the CIDPro™ certification, who understand the full stack from authentication protocols to access governance to privileged identity to machine identity — are the ones who lead those organisations.

Whatever role you are targeting, the foundations in this book will serve you. Start with the chapters most relevant to your current or target role. Build your lab. Engage with the community. And earn the credential that proves your depth in the discipline that matters most.